

DESIGN PSYCHOLOGY

# Cross-Culture Buddy System

Michelle Leung, CID: 06071578

Ruwen Li, CID: 06059695

Yinuo Pang, CID: 06060377

Payal Chand, CID: 06067958

Alexandra Wagner: 06068170



# AGENDA

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002 THE PROBLEM

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003 THE INTERVENTION

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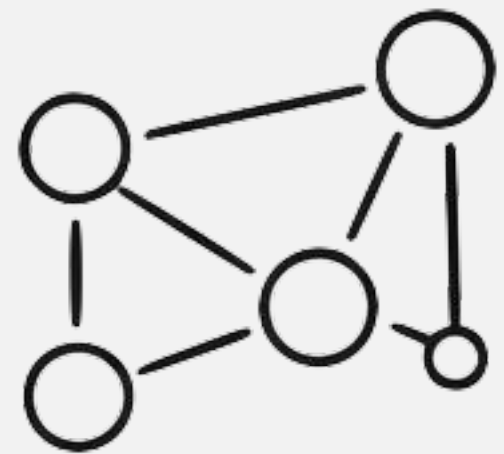
003 JUSTIFICATION

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004 THEORY OF CHANGE

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# OUR ROLES



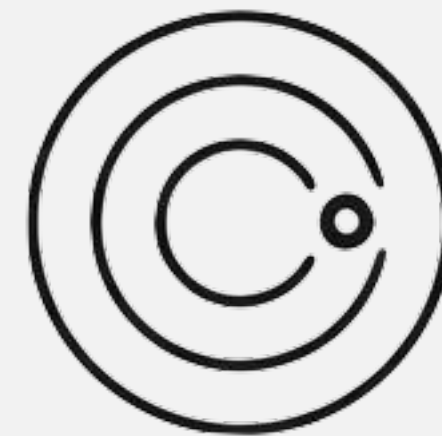
**Payal**

Systems &  
Theory Lead



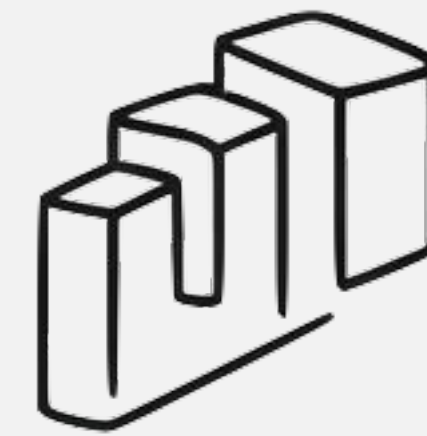
**Ruwen**

User Research  
Lead



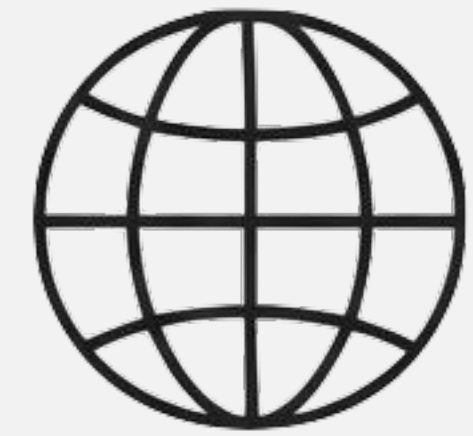
**Michelle**

Market  
Research Lead



**Alexandra**

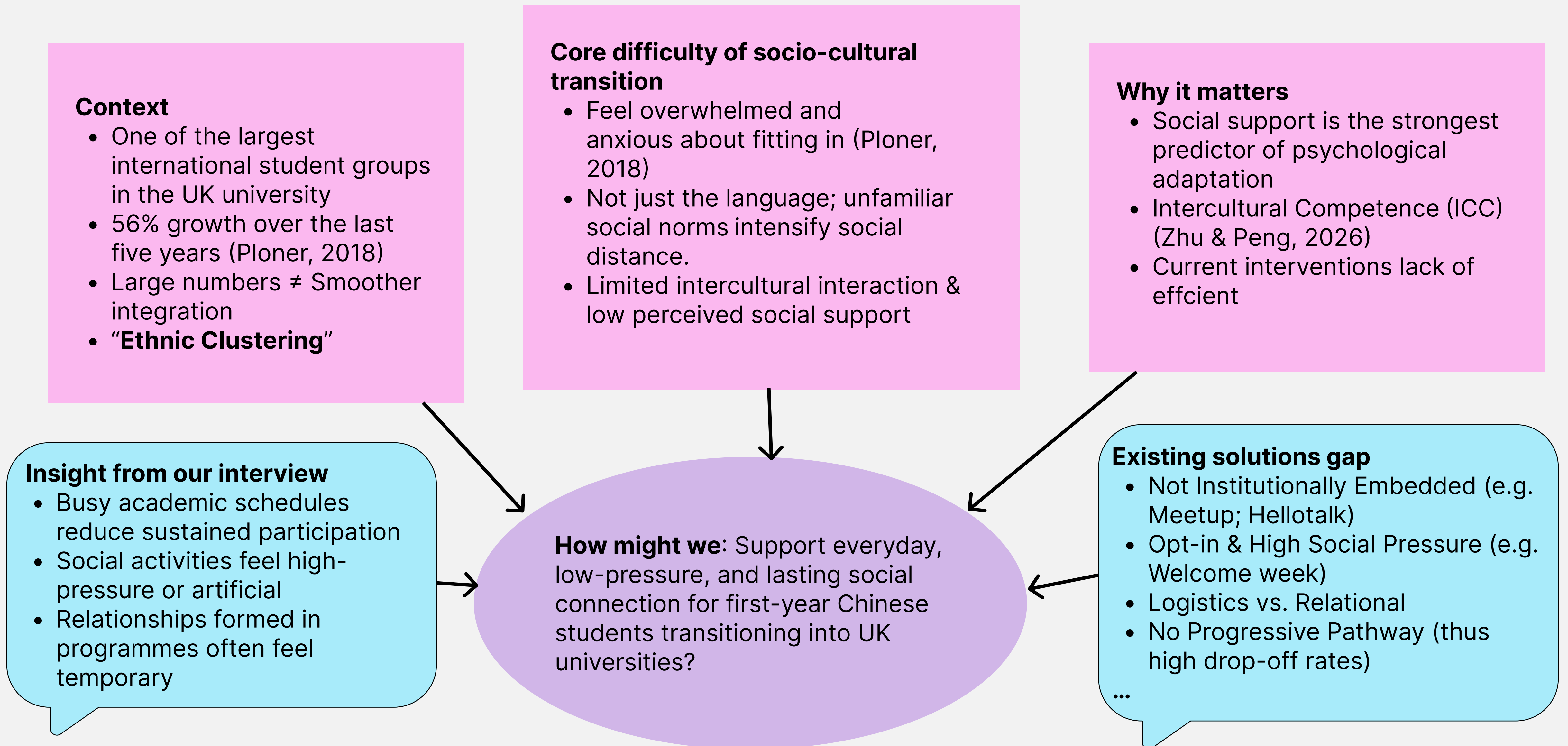
Operations  
Lead



**Yinuo**

Cultural Insight  
Lead

# The Socio-Cultural Transition Challenge For First-Year Chinese Students In The UK



# COM-B Exploration For Ethnic Clustering

## COM-B Analysis

- **Capability:**
  - Low confidence navigating UK social norms
  - Uncertainty about initiating cross-cultural interaction
  - Limited perceived conversational competence
- **Opportunity:**
  - Social networks clustered by nationality
  - Few structured, low-stakes host–international contact opportunities
  - No or limited everyday interaction spaces
- **Motivation:**
  - Co-national groups provide immediate belonging and psychological safety
  - Cross-cultural interaction feels effortful and uncertain
  - High fear of embarrassment/ judgment due to english fluency
  - Short-term comfort outweighs long-term adaptation goals

**Behaviour:** Chinese international students primarily socialise within co-national groups and avoid sustained interaction with host students.



## Insights:

- Cross-cultural interactions
- Low burden/efforts
- Long-term adaptation

**How might we** design structured, low-pressure cross-cultural contact that disrupts ethnic clustering and accelerates socio-cultural adaptation?

# DESIGN PSYCHOLOGY | INTERVENTION

## Addressing the Gap:

Chinese students lack everyday emotional and relational support, staying within cultural bubbles. This programme facilitates genuine peer connections through interest-based matching and structured, low-pressure contact.

## INTEREST-BASED BUDDY SYSTEM PROGRAM From optional social exposure → scaffolded relationships

### Programme Overview:

A voluntary, university-facilitated buddy programme pairing new Chinese international students with UK home students (2:1 ratio) based on shared academic, linguistic, and personal interests to support socio-cultural adaptation led by senior year home (UK) & Chinese student representative.

**Target Group:** New (undergraduate & postgraduate) Chinese international students and home students

### Intervention Structure

#### Phase 1: Pre-Arrival

- Students complete matching form (course/interests/languages)
- Algorithmic pairing prioritizes: Course → Language interests → Hobbies/sports → Age → Cultural background
- Students paired based on form (2 Chinese students, 1 Host student)
- Contact exchange for connection before school starts

#### Phase 2: Orientation Week

- Free lunch event (university-provided) with all participating students
- First structured face-to-face meeting with buddy group

#### Phase 3: Sustained Contact

- Voluntary lunchtime meet-ups
- Incentivised through meal discount (£3 per person)
- Small subsidy for shared interest activities (sports, events, hobbies)

# Behavior Rationale

## Why This Design Works: Evidence-Based Mechanisms

This intervention integrates intergroup contact theory, homophily, and self-determination theory to support sustained socio-cultural adaptation.

### 1. Why structured cross-cultural contact?

- Institutional, equal-status interaction reduces intergroup distance
- Host-national friendships predict stronger adaptation
- Early contact accelerates integration

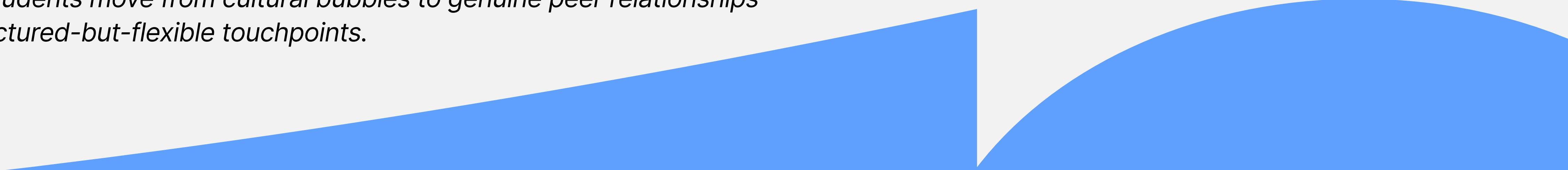
### 2. Why this design sustains over time?

- Similarity lowers social uncertainty
- Supports competence, relatedness, and autonomy
- Intrinsic motivation sustains engagement

### 3. Why this delivery format works in practice?

- Low-pressure, short-duration touchpoints
- Built-in social structure reduces awkwardness
- Financial support lowers access barriers

*Leading to students move from cultural bubbles to genuine peer relationships through structured-but-flexible touchpoints.*



# Why structured cross-cultural contact?

## Intergroup contact theory

Proposed by Allport (1954)

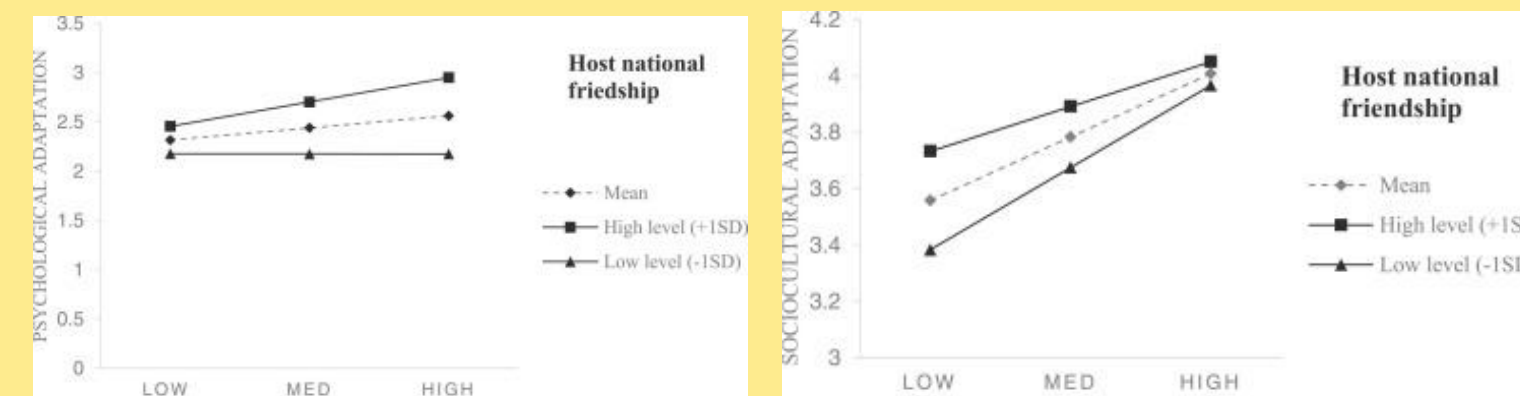
**Concept:** through meaningful, institutionally supported collaborative interactions between members from different social identity groups, prejudice will be decreased.

**For international students**, such interactions provide a deeper understanding of **the host culture's norms, values, and practices, facilitating adaptation.**

Positive contact promotes **interpersonal relationships, language proficiency, community engagement, ecological adaptation, and academic performance**, which are key aspects of **sociocultural adjustment.**

## The implementation

Host national friendships are significantly positively linked to both psychological adaptation and socio-cultural adaptation. (Sheng, Dai, & Lei, 2022)



Host-national friendship **moderates the relationship between academic adjustment and sociocultural adjustment**, whereas co-national friendships and friendships with students from other countries **do not demonstrate this moderating effect.**

## Why 2-on-1

Interviewee 1:  
"the student might be overly rely on the one local student since they might already have their group"

Our recommendations based on RAMP's experience to improve existing programs designed to facilitate acculturation and/or integration of i-Students, including improving RAMP are as follows. .... (E) **No more than two mentees should be assigned to a mentor.....** (Pekerti, van de Vijver, Moeller, Okimoto, & Edwards, 2021)

## Why this design sustains over time

Autonomously motivated engagement is more likely to be sustained and integrated over time (Ryan & Deci, 2000), and frequent contact with host students has been linked to stronger socio-cultural adaptation (Szabó et al., 2020).

### Value Homophily

**Homophily** = tendency to form ties with similar others (McPherson et al., 2001)

Similarity-based matching:

- Reduces social uncertainty
- Makes conversations easier
- Increases perceived similarity
- Accelerates trust

Supports Relatedness and Competence in SDT

### Self-Determination Theory

- **Competence:** Interest overlap gives students something they already feel skilled talking about
- **Relatedness:** Interest-based pairing facilitates early belonging and social acceptance in the host context
- **Autonomy:** voluntary continuation beyond structured lunch

### Intrinsic Motivation to Engage with UK Students

- Greater persistence after awkward or negative interactions
- Increased voluntary exposure to host culture
- Deeper emotional and cognitive engagement
- Faster development of socio-cultural competence
- More stable, sustainable adaptation over time

Interviewee 2:

"I feel like when people **share common hobbies, it is much easier to integrate quickly**. For example, many host nation students are interested in Chinese anime-related culture, which creates a natural starting point for conversation."

# Why this delivery format works in practice → Lunch time bonding

## Commensality (Mensah & Tuomainen, 2024)

**Concept:** The act of eating with others is an important cultural practice that enables many social functions e.g., creation of shared experience, identity construction, and social engagement.

- Less burden: having lunch together does not act as an additional event to the schedule + short duration (30 to 45 min)
- Food reduces awkwardness: the built-in structure of ordering, trying, reacting)

Concern: Research suggests that people with low incomes (in this case, students) have limited capacity to engage in social eating activities (Smith & Harvey, 2021)  
→ reduce financial burden through meal discount

## Eating Alone Together Probe (Grevet et al., 2012)

A probe that provide information of people's mealtime preferences to increase commensal meal opportunities

|                                                            |                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Catherine</b><br>Eating out                             | <b>Clara</b><br>Eating at home<br><i>Currently cooking</i> |
| <b>Jake</b><br>Eating at home<br><i>Currently cleaning</i> | <b>Henry</b><br>Eating at home                             |

- more mealtimes together = more social interaction
- suggests future intervention supporting people without traditional commensality

## DESIGN PSYCHOLOGY | BEHAVIOR MODELING

### COM-B Analysis

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**Behaviour:** Chinese international students primarily socialise within co-national groups and avoid sustained interaction with host students.

- Interest-based matching provides immediate common ground
- Structured first meeting reduces interactional ambiguity
- Repeated contact builds conversational competence

- University-run programme legitimises interaction
- Matched pairing creates built-in cross-cultural contact
- Scheduled touchpoints ensure repeated exposure

- Value homophily increases perceived similarity
- Supports SDT needs:
  - Relatedness → early belonging
  - Competence → confidence in interaction
  - Autonomy → voluntary participation
- Strengthens intrinsic motivation to continue engaging

# Theory of Change Map: Interest-based Buddy System for Chinese Students in UK Universities

## Prerequisites

- University endorsement and orientation integration
- Pool of trained host students
- Matching platform + student data access
- Budget for one launch event + small activity subsidy

## Assumptions

- Chinese students will opt into and attend the initial event
- Sufficient host students volunteer for 2:1 matching
- Matching data (interests + language) is accurate enough to pair effectively
- Meal discounts motivate at least one follow-up meetup
- Staff can manage matching and track discount use

## Unintended Outcomes

- Network clustering within buddy triad (third-wheel)
- Disengagement by one student over time
- Incentives reduce intrinsic motivation

## Case

Chinese international students often form co-national networks early, limiting cross-cultural integration. While supportive, these networks may reduce engagement with host students. Evidence shows that host-national interaction improves socio-cultural adaptation and well-being, especially when initiated early. This intervention uses interest-based matching during orientation, pairing two Chinese students with one host student to create low-pressure, sustained cross-cultural contact.

## Stakeholders

**Primary beneficiaries:** First-year / transfer / postgraduate Chinese international students

**Secondary beneficiaries:** Host (domestic) students, broader international student community

**University stakeholders:** International student office, student experience / wellbeing teams, orientation coordinators

**Delivery partners:** Student unions, cultural societies, dining services (for subsidy mechanism)

**Wider society:** University community cohesion, future globally integrated graduates

## Activities

- Students complete interest-based matching form
- Algorithm pairs 2 Chinese students + 1 host student
- Pre-term online introduction (WhatsApp group)
- Mandatory first meeting at orientation (free lunch event)
- Offer voluntary but incentivised shared activities (meal discounts)
- Provide access to buddy community forum
- Monitor early engagement and repeat interactions

## Inputs

- Student survey
- Matching algorithm (course + interests + language level)
- Pre-term WeChat/WhatsApp group introduction
- Orientation lunch (structured ice-breakers)
- Meal subsidy for shared lunch
- Short adaptation survey (pre/post)

## Outputs

Participation

- % of eligible students opting in
- Buddy groups successfully matched
- Orientation attendance rate

Engagement

- Buddy discount redemptions
- % of buddy groups using discount at least once
- Average repeat redemptions per group

## Outcomes

### • Psychological Adaptation

- Increased belonging (pre-post change)
- Increased perceived social competence
- Reduced reported social isolation

### • Behavioural Integration

- Participation in mixed social events beyond buddy
- Continued interaction beyond subsidy use

## Impact Goals

- Improved socio-cultural adaptation
- Sustained cross-cultural networks
- Higher first-year retention
- Improved student wellbeing

# Intervention Matching Logic

Each student completes a form including:

- Course/department
- Languages spoken + confidence level
- 5–8 selectable interests
- Age range
- Optional nationality preference

Matches are scored using weighted similarity:

- Course similarity → highest weight
- Shared interests → high weight
- Shared language → medium weight
- Age proximity → low weight
- Nationality → minimal weight (to avoid clustering)

Top-scoring combinations are grouped into 2 Chinese + 1 host triads.

Lesk, S., & Montaldo, M. (2018)

1. Full Name

2. Email Address (University email only)

3. Student Status

☐ Chinese Student☐ Home/Host Student

4. Course / Department Select your course / department

5. Year of Study

☐ 1st Year☐ 2nd Year☐ 3rd Year☐ Postgraduate☐ PhD

Section 2: Language & Communication

6. Languages Spoken

☐ English☐ Chinese☐ French☐ German

☐ Japanese☐ Korean☐ Other:

Section 3: Interests

Select 5–8 interests you genuinely enjoy (5–8 selections required)

☐ Fitness / Gym☐ Running☐ Hiking / Nature☐ Volunteering

☐ Film & TV☐ Gaming☐ Somewhat confident☐ Cultural exchange

☐ Tech / AI☐ Startups☐ Entrepreneurs☐ Nightlife

☐ Fashion☐ Music☐ Board games☐ Sports (playing)

☐ Photography☐ Music☐ Sports (watching)☐ Other:

Section 4: Age Range

☐ 18–20☐ 21–23☐ 24–26☐ 27+

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